

Top 10 Fast Tracks

The Digit DVD you got along with this issue has PDFs of the 10 most popular Fast Tracks Digit has ever published

Icons of Trust 2012

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eerie glow to your cabinet; just make sure to install UV lights or you'll be left with only coloured tubes! For a true case mod however, forget the traditional cabinet designs. Let your imagination run wild. People have built computers into mannequins, microwave ovens, toasters, desks, alloy wheels and even remote control cars and stuffed teddy bears. Other than the usual limitations of having your CPU on the motherboard, among other things, your HDD, PSU, etc. can be placed wherever you like and their location and orientation is limited only by cable length. Slot loading ODDs are superb as you can mask them very easily; PWM fan controllers with LCDs look really cool and you can also carefully manage your airflow with them.

Before starting work on the case make sure that you're very clear about what it is that you want to make. Blueprints in the form of rough sketches, at least, are a good idea. Once you know what you want, it's time to choose the materials. While doing this, bear in mind the weight of the components that you'll be using. PSUs are heavy and would require a correspondingly sturdy material. The motherboard also needs proper support. While you don't require a flat surface to mount the motherboard on, you must ensure that the screw mounts are level and isolated. Graphics cards and CPU coolers can also be quite heavy and your motherboard should be mounted in such a way as to distribute the load uniformly. When mounting acrylic sheets in a panel, ensure that the sheet is mounted using rubber strips held together with silica gel or something similar. You wouldn't want it to keep popping out, would you? Basically, once you're clear about the key support points, the motherboard screw-holes, hard disk and optical disk mount points, graphics card screws, fan/radiator mounts, etc., you can then freely do what you like with the rest of the design. Make liberal use of masking tape. You can tape up, say, a side panel in which you want to fit a window and then sketch a neat shape that you want to carve. That way, you can easily modify your design at the last minute without damaging the surface finish of your panel.



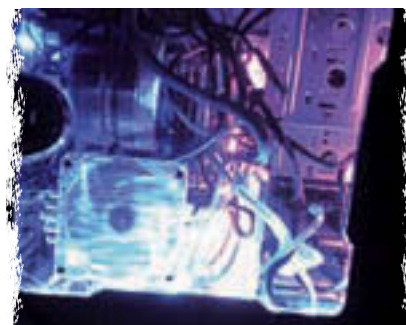
A "steampunked" case mod



Go wild with LEDs and UV reactive tubes!



One of the more tame case mods.



An example of bad cable management.

Materials like plaster of paris can be used for masking areas, as well as for creative modelling. You can quite easily design a castle with crenelated walls and gargoyles strewn all over the place,

SAFETY FIRST

Under any circumstances, please remember that your safety is of the utmost importance while building or modding your case. Safety goggles and gloves, etc are needed, but you also need to know what you're doing. Ignorance is not bliss in this case, it will more likely result in a chopped off finger or a few missing teeth. You don't want to put your actual blood and tears into your work. Power tools and even hacksaws and tin snips can be extremely dangerous and unless you have had previous experience with them (mechanical engineers rejoice!), DO NOT mess around with them without proper supervision. Read all safety instructions first before proceeding and when messing with paints and chemicals, ensure that you have a face mask as sometimes the fumes can be poisonous.



Who says you need a box?

or make the case look like some craggy mountain or some sort of hideous beast, like maybe a grinning chimpanzee whose mouth hides your USB slots. Be sure not to impede the functionality of the case by covering up some handy screw hole or button.

Now for the finishing touches. Putty is good. A bit of sanding and grinding will get rid of sharp edges. Sandpaper should suffice but you might need something stronger depending on the materials you chose. A lick of paint can give your case that much needed colour. Spray paint is the easiest option. If you have access to a proper garage and workshop, you can even try automotive paint to give your case a more professional look. Apply varnish as well so as to preserve the paint.

Don't forget to post the pics on our facebook and twitter pages! Who knows, the best case might end up getting featured in the magazine!